

# Composite vs. Hardwood Decking.

Updated July 2026 · [hakadecks.com/composite-vs-hardwood-decking-colorado](https://hakadecks.com/composite-vs-hardwood-decking-colorado)

Short version: composite costs more per board and less per decade. Hardwood looks and feels like nothing else — if you'll actually maintain it. Here's how they compare at Colorado altitude, where UV and freeze-thaw cycles punish both.

|                       | Composite              | Hardwood                                |
|-----------------------|------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| <b>Installed cost</b> | \$40–70 / sq ft        | \$50–85 / sq ft                         |
| <b>Annual upkeep</b>  | Soap and water         | Clean, sand spots, re-oil every 1–2 yrs |
| <b>Lifespan</b>       | 25–50 yrs (warrantied) | 20–40 yrs (maintained)                  |
| <b>Colorado UV</b>    | Fade-warrantied caps   | Silvers fast without oil                |
| <b>Feel underfoot</b> | Warmer in full sun     | Cooler, real wood grain                 |

## Pick composite if...

You want weekends on the deck, not maintaining it. Modern capped boards (Trex, TimberTech, Deckorators — we install all three) have real 25–50 year fade and stain warranties, and at 5,000+ ft that matters: our UV is roughly 25% stronger than sea level. About 90% of what we build is composite.

## Pick hardwood if...

Nothing else will do. Ipe and cumaru are gorgeous, dense, and cooler underfoot. The honest trade: budget a re-oil every year or two, or accept the silver-gray patina. Skip the middle ground — a neglected hardwood deck costs more to rescue than it did to build.

## What about redwood or cedar?

The budget-friendly classic. Lower upfront cost (\$25–45 / sq ft installed), but softer boards and yearly staining in our climate. Fine for ground-level decks you plan to replace in 15–20 years; we'd steer walk-outs and high decks to composite.

Want to see both in person? We keep samples of every line we install — composite, PVC, and hardwood — and a free on-site consultation puts them in your actual light, against your actual house. 720-589-5680 · [hakadecks.com/contact](https://hakadecks.com/contact)